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BURNING MAN 2001
my version of a spiritual journey

Burning man was so amazing. I didn't dare close my eyes - there was always something else to marvel at, and as much as I tried to be a participant and not just a spectator, I think that I probably spent most of the week with my mouth slack and my eyes glazed over at all the beauty and creativity that surrounded me. Those people brought the desert to life with their creations and their energy, energy that swept us up and was around us with each step. Out in the desert the stars felt like they were at our fingertips every moment of the night. The darkness was so close and so black we felt like we could just reach out and touch it, and it would feel as velvety as the wind that blew a little bit all the time against the natural desert heat. Contrast that darkness to the lights all around us; so alive for a place without electricity; flashing and blinking and changing at every pulse of the base. Lights that called to those who would - come out of the darkness into the light. Come into the warmth of people sharing and interacting and coming together as one out in the middle of nowhere. As they never would anywhere in society short of a rave or a party and even then..

It was impossible to look across the playa and not see some sort of creature or creation moving along, strung together out of lights and pipes, each businessman and career-woman turned electrician showing off for the world to admire.

Focusing on the road was difficult as we drove up because of the constant flashes of light and flame, and the trance music pulsing across the Playa. Windows rolled up tight against the swirling playa dust, we had no idea what was in store for us. After being questioned about our water supply “How much water do you have for how many people?” “Don’t forget to drink it all!” we were allowed to continue slowly down the dusty road towards the bright lights and sounds the desert floor seemed to emit. We kept looking at each other, excited and nervous, not sure about what we were undertaking, only feeling as though together, along with eight suitcases of water and a weeks worth of dried fruit, we could survive anything the desert had to offer. My boyfriend at the time, Theo, and I drove in with the instruction to “find a place to camp” which theoretically didn’t sound too hard. However, after passing street after street of trailers and tents we decided it was going to be more difficult than we had previously imagined. Finally, we randomly chose a street to turn onto, and pulled into an empty looking sand patch on a corner, only to be approached by older naked man with a bobbing camp lantern who told us that he was expecting more people so we couldn’t park there. Windows up, about to drive off, the man must have noticed our dejected look, and lead us around the corner to a little area perfect for our tent.

The wind felt so fresh and clean, unlike any other any I have ever felt. It wrapped around us and cooled us, although it was not hot outside. And with me, I am always cold; I just have a lower body temperature in general, so the fact that I was never cold at all was amazing. Something about being in the desert kept me warm enough the whole time. Setting up the tent by headlights, too excited to want to do anything but look around, and

yet trying to be reasonable at the same time. “When we get back tonight, we’ll just want to go to sleep.” So we made camp, all the while hearing music, shouts of laughter, and noise that sounded suspiciously like cannons being shot off in the distance. Having been warned about the playa dust, “it dries out your skin, don’t touch it if you don’t have to,” I was extremely cautious, doing my best to never come in contact the ground. Curiosity got the best of me, however and I reached down and picked up the softest handful of anything I have ever touched, letting it slip through my fingertips. How could something so feathery be harmful to skin? Inspecting my hand in the lantern-light, I realized what they had meant when they warned me; my hand was covered in the dust that wasn’t about to just brush off. I did know enough to not wash my hands; playa turns first to quicksand, and then to clay when it is wet, so I went with the only other solution, wiping my hands on my jeans. At that moment, I left the real world, one in which I am so fickle about cleanliness, behind. Finally, after a quick snack (the food already tasted dusty) we were off to explore.

I got painted red. Walking around in a bathing suit shoes, (before I got over being worried about playa-foot) we strolled past a camp strewn with kiddie pools full of what looked like nasty colored water at the bottom of them, and a bunch of pesticide sprayers all around them. We didn’t know what to think - until a guy asked us if we wanted to be painted. Sure. I took off my shoes and stepped into the pool, but he just kept looking at me expecting something more.

“Aren’t you going to take off your swimsuit?”

“Hmmm.” I thought about this. Are you sure, asked Theo’s glance, but as long as he was with me... why not. So off it came. I stood in a pool, closed my eyes, and got coated down with a pesticide sprayer full of red, the guy stopping to smooth the color where it was uneven. The light wind was cold on my skin where it was wet, and the air was thick with paint around me; all intensified by my eyes being closed. I could taste the acidity of the paint without it actually being in my mouth, and I could feel the curious glances of the people walking by. I think it was the first time in my life where a non family man had touched me the way he did -- completely non-sexually. Like I wasn’t even anything except a canvas. He touched my breasts, my stomach, my legs - just smoothing the paint on me.

I walked away from his camp, now red, with a new respect for men, and for artists who can do art and separate it from anything else in the world. And also, a new respect for myself. Here I was, walking around in the random desert, not wearing anything except red paint and marveling at my lack of self-consciousness. For the time that I was painted, I was a participating member of Burning Man, no longer a spectator, but an art project as I was. I felt like I was giving back to the festival from which I was taking so much - I could finally be something for others to look at as opposed to simply a spectator. And that feeling, that freeness - is one that has stayed with me and probably always will. I am much less body conscious now than I have ever been, with my own body, and with those of others. It’s not easy to like our bodies when everything tells us we need to look differently than we do, but being around so many naked people who didn’t care less

about their appearances, and cared even less about mine, put it into perspective. I thought, “Wow, if these people don’t care what I look like or what they look like, why should I worry.” And so I don’t worry anymore. Well, that’s not entirely true, but I try really hard not to, and that’s something I never would have done before seeing all the naked baby boomers.

Burning Man is a week long pagan-esque festival held out in the desert of Nevada every year for the past eight or so years. It began as a small gathering on the beach in San Francisco, and extended to thousands of people (this past year it was about 35,000) coming together in tents and trailers to form Black Rock City, in the shape of a semi circle around The Man. The Man, the center of the festival, is an enormous man-figure made out of electricity and pyrotechnics, which is burned on the Saturday night of Labor Day weekend, as a denunciation of all that is structured and mundane about society. People make camps as the entertainment, everything from dance clubs to playgrounds, all constructed by materials that have been hauled out to the desert. There is no electricity, no running water, no phones, nothing. Only miles and miles of dust, and what people make to display. People go to Burning Man to let go for a week, to free themselves from their bosses and their lives, to walk naked in the sunshine and the dust and be awed by the creativity inspired by the dry air.

We did LSD one of the nights, and aside from smoking pot and getting a little bit drunk a couple of times, it was the most intense drug I have ever taken. It was weird because I had a whole bunch of expectations of what it was going to be like and it wasn’t like any of them; it was very surreal and wonderful. For a while I wasn’t feeling anything

except kind of warmth in my stomach, and because I had only taken one tab, I thought maybe nothing was going to happen to me. Then we were walking across the playa and I looked up and the whole side of the city that we were walking towards kind of rippled as if I was looking at it through heat waves. I felt really light and airy, and everything I thought about seemed so simple and so clear to me. There was nothing I couldn't solve right then, at that moment, because it all made perfect sense, so I was free to move on and think about more important things, like, why had I never noticed the intricacies of a burning log before. So we walked all over the playa, seriously tripping, stopping to look at every statue and art structure as though we were seeing it for the first time, because we pretty much were. Being on LSD makes everything come into a newer light, so all our senses were intensified. The dust in my toes felt like walking through water, and the wind hitting my back felt so strong. I felt so light I was sure if I could jump high enough I would have taken off and flown forever. I didn't have any hallucinations, because I only did one tab, but all the things I looked at, like the inside of the fire, or the dust blowing across the desert seemed to have more depth than they usually would have. People appeared larger than life, and their words and actions affected me so much more. One of the few names I remember from the whole week of meeting so many people was this guy who I met while I was tripping. His name was Carl from Canada, and he lifted me out of a trunk bed onto the ground because I was afraid of falling, and no one else in my group was paying attention. His little act of kindness made such a lasting impression on me, because it was an act of pure humanity, and I was able to look into his eyes and thank him for such a simple thing that meant so much to me. I think that feeling, of being so free

while I was on acid, is one of the stronger sentiments I will take from Burning Man, because I try to be like that all the time now. Not to act like I am tripping, but to look at everything and everyone like I am seeing it for the first time, so that I can be judgment free, and always feel a sense of newness. It's pretty easy to do at the moment - living in Santa Cruz and being in college everything is completely new, but even when I got home, I tried regarding everything with a clean mind, and it helped me to see past all the pretenses and expectations through to what I was really looking at. Hopefully that's something that I will always be able to do.

I didn't go to Burning Man to escape anything; I went because I had heard that it was fun, and I thought that it would be a nice way to end the summer before moving forward into college. With my high school boyfriend in tow, and my older sister's dust stained camping gear from last year, I wanted only to sit back and be entertained. Little did I know how much more I would do than just watch, and how much everything that I saw would effect my mentality after Burning Man was over. For one, it made me look at everything as potential for next year. "Oh, I could make an art-car out of that, or a cool theme-site with that as an idea." But also, it affects the way I look at people now. People are so cold and curt to each other so much of the time; always business orientated and in a hurry. Even after September 11, which definitely brought the country closer together, people are still so distant and competitive, and Burning Man showed me a potential for human spirit that I have never experienced. I supposed if I had been around to experience the Hippie Movement in the 60s I might know more about thousands of people coming together and just embracing being human together, but Burning Man was like nothing I

have ever seen. It warmed my heart to see people cooperating and communicating and living as one, because it forced me to remember that that is a possibility for human kind.

One morning I was standing at my camp trying to scrub the red paint off me the next day using the least amount of water possible. It was a very slow process and I wasn't having much luck because I must have had eight layers of paint on. A neighbor came over to say "Hear that Whistle? That's the water truck, it's about to come by, hurry up." There was this huge truck that looked like a gas tanker truck except that it was spraying water out of the back in a jet stream. The water kept the roads from getting too dusty, making it easier for bikes and art cars, but the funny thing about it was that there were 20 people running behind it, all in various states of clothed, using the spray as a shower. So I joined the masses, scrubbing the paint off of myself, and skipping to keep up with the fast paced truck. The playa mud between my toes felt squishy and fresh like when we were in preschool and played in the mud puddles, and I didn't have to worry that I was mostly naked and that I don't like my thighs because everyone was naked and nobody cared. Nobody was even looking at me.

In high school Theo and I as a couple were just no more than a "high school relationship," kids like everyone else; we did stupid things for fun and were just generally immature, but it was okay because so was everyone. At the end of senior year, it became clear that most of the seniors were ready to leave; we just felt too old for high school, although we couldn't really place the feeling. I felt the same way when I went back to my high school right before my trip to Burning Man, just a sense of being finished with the high school "scene" in which I had partaken of for so long. I think that my individuation

process began in high school, during which my ego and persona emerged, but were not yet fully developed. Theo and I did everything together, to the point where we brought our families together at holidays, and to the point where the people we knew didn't think of us as individuals anymore, we came as a pair. It was hard for me to imagine being without him, both in the long and short term. So, because Theo was so much a part of my high school experience, in that we did so much growing up together, he consisted of a large part of my personality.

At the end of high school, I felt that I needed some kind of closure to my life as it had been so far. All that closure meant was that, for some reason, I felt like a chapter of my life was ending, that no matter what, things were never going to be the same again after I moved out and started being somewhat independent. I wasn't even sure of what to do about the situation with Theo, because I was going off to college and he was not. The fact that he wasn't going to college was a big deal to me, because more than that, he didn't graduate. And although I told myself that not graduating was not a big deal, to me it really was, because it seemed like such an indication of his future, and therefore, our future because we were still a couple. Also, at home, my mother had not been employed for about six months, and she was becoming really anxious and bored about being home all the time, which was putting tension on the rest of the family. I felt guilty for going off to college because I knew how much of a financial burden it was going to be on my family, and yet they were encouraging me to go so strongly that I was very torn. I felt a sense of restlessness regarding all the most important aspects of my life.

The night we did LSD we didn't sleep at all, and so at dawn, we went to The Man and sat on him to watch the sun rise. There was a bunch of people already there, and it was the only time that we were really cold, because the wind was blowing and we were coming off our trip, and right before dawn is the coldest time of night anyway. So we were huddled up on The Man with all the other people, bunched up really close and I felt so good and safe surrounded by all those strangers, and we were all being silly, ohhing and ahhing every time a new pink streak was added to the grey sky. It was so beautiful to watch the earth shift and the sun get higher up into the sky. Someone was walking around with a mirror sticking it in people's faces and making them say "I am beautiful," and it was really funny to watch people's reactions. Some people said it right away, and some people had to be convinced. It took me a long time to look in that mirror, but I eventually said what the hell, and just let go. Watching the sun rise that morning and then going back to our site, making clam chowder from a can and eating it from the pot is one of my favorite memories from the whole week. Clam chowder had never tasted so good, lighting a camp stove had never been such an accomplishment, and laying down in the tent with the sounds of the city coming to life had never been so pleasant. Being tired and on drugs, my senses were heightened to the point where every bite of food was sensual, and the inside of my sleeping bag felt like the finest of cloth.

When I got to Burning Man, it wasn't as though my life suddenly made sense to me; it was more like, I didn't have to worry any more. Wandering around on the playa at night, my bare feet in the soft playa dust and the cold night wind cutting the natural warmth of the desert was enough to help complete and reassure me; to help me feel like

everything would be alright if I gave it time. It wasn't as though I had a peak experience, like that everything was suddenly right in the world and for a few moments everything made perfect sense to me, but in a way the whole five days for which I was there was a peak experience in itself. For five days I was worry free, concentrating only of basic survival of drinking enough water and putting sunscreen on the parts of me that weren't used to being exposed to the sun. When I got home it was easy for me to pack up my room and prepare to leave. I am sure that I will go to Burning Man next year, the memories I have from it draw me like an addiction, but I don't know if my experiences there will ever be as powerful as this first year, the year in which my world was turned upside down, and I emerged ready to be a different version of myself. I drove in on Wednesday still in my High School mentality of immaturity and insecurity, and came out on Sunday as much more of an adult, ready to move forward out of the house, into college, beyond the safety of the world to which I was so accustomed.

I arrived at a hotel on the Oregon border at about midnight on Sunday night, after having driven for five or six hours out of Nevada. My feet left dusty colored footprints across the carpet on the way to the shower, and the ring of dust around the bathtub floor was enough to make anyone wonder where all that dirt could have come from. I showered for a full half hour, marveling at the hot running water, the soap, the clean towels as if I had never been in civilization before. Climbing into bed was the best though, feeling clean and moisturized, the soft sheets and blankets...and then, missing the smell of the desert, longing for the chill from the wind, the bass thumping across the playa, the hard ground beneath me.

I left the playa counting the days till next year, waving and honking at other dust covered cars along the highways - Anxious to share the simple pleasures of my experience with the world, wishing for everyone the freeness I felt for those few short days. My heart is open, my mind is blown, and I am forever grateful that I was able to partake in an event so wonderful and special, and that I was so ready.